any leading Chinese troops could be at this stage should they spill out into the plains.

In addition, the IV Corps reserve, 23 Division, was also on its way from Nagaland with six infantry battalions to supplement the existing troops on the North Bank. General Thapar already seemed to have made up his mind that both banks of the Brahmaputra Valley had to be evacuated while IV Corps with all remaining forces should fall back on Siliguri to the west. Improbable as it may sound, it seemed the army chief had mentally accepted Bogey Sen's bizarre suggestion to surrender Assam. The meeting ended inconclusively.

Thapar then asked Palit to accompany him to his office. This would be the last formal meeting between them. In his meeting with the prime minister after their return from Tezpur, where he offered to resign, Thapar said he had deliberately not recommended replacing the Eastern Army Commander. If his resignation was accepted, he felt it would be more prudent for his successor to take whatever steps he deemed necessary.

Before leaving Thapar's office, Palit made one last attempt to get the chief on board for the defence of Assam: 'If we were to withdraw from the South Bank we would literally be deserting the Assamese people, for which they would never forgive us. It is even possible that parts of Assam would be lost to India forever whether or not the Chinese crossed the Brahmaputra, because the Pakistanis might decide to share in the spoils of war and occupy the Garo and Jaintia Hills or even the whole South Bank including the oil wells of Digboi.'

The colour drained from Thapar's face. Obviously, he had not fully thought through the implications of a withdrawal. The facts now seemed to overwhelm him. 'I told the PM last night that I may have to withdraw from Assam. But I agree with you—it would be an unimaginable disaster. I'll think it over.'

However, it was already too late. The decision to let Thapar go had been taken and the chief, who had throughout his tenure functioned as a lame duck in the shadow of Kaul was now a non-entity. To keep some sort of fig leaf in place, he was told by the government that he should resign on grounds of ill health and not over the NEFA debacle.

Back in Tezpur, Kaul was adding considerably to the spreading panic by making absurd and wild statements while characteristically zipping around in a helicopter from one valley to the other. Quite used to taking decisions